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JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Gymnast Lexi Kent, 18, worked on her beam routine at Beyond Gymnastics in Burlington.

15 MILLION MISSED DAYS

IN THIS COMPETITION, CLASSES LEFT ON SIDELINES

As club leagues grow in popularity, more young athletes are skipping school for tournaments, even as varsity teams help engage others

By Christopher Huffaker and Marcela Rodrigues
GLOBE STAFF

(Second in three-part series)

While her classmates wrestled with physics equations at Canton High School, Soley Rodriguez Martinez rolled a suitcase through Logan International Airport, lugging volleyball uniforms, knee pads, and court shoes.

The 17-year-old was headed to Daytona Beach for another tournament.

During her junior year alone, Rodriguez Martinez traveled to Puerto Rico, New York City, Atlanta, and Orlando, each trip requiring her to miss between two and four days of school. She is as strong a student as she is a digger, but on the plane last May she worried about physics catch-up work as she polished an essay for AP English class.

The explosion of club volleyball, hockey, soccer, basketball, and other travel teams is pulling scores of student athletes out of class. Some elite players have always prioritized sports over school, but administrators say more and more students are now skipping class for far-flung tournaments.

The growing popularity of out-of-school sports has added fuel to a post-pandemic surge in chronic absenteeism. Last year, a half-decade after schools closed, more than 17 percent of students were chronically absent, meaning they missed a day every two weeks on average. All those absences matter academically, and can affect test scores, dropout rates, college enrollment, and future earning potential.

Club sports can also hurt students who don't participate, by undercutting school-

SPORTS, Page A6

During the 2023–24 school year, Indiana varsity athletes were less likely to be absent each day than nonathletes.

6.5% All students

5.6% Athletes out of season

4.7% Athletes in season

Suffield headmaster resigns amid probe

School leader to focus on 'health' as he faces IRS investigation into his finances

By Mike Damiano
GLOBE STAFF

The longtime headmaster of Suffield Academy, who is facing an IRS probe amid scrutiny of his ties to a Chinese company run by a former Suffield board member, has resigned his position as head of school.

"After careful reflection, I have decided to step down to focus on my health," Charles Cahn III said in a statement sent to the school's mailing list by his successor, Casey Hagerman Bobo, on Sunday.

The announcement of Cahn's resignation comes days after it was revealed that he had gone missing the same day Suffield announced the IRS probe into his finances, and four days after the Globe reported on his ties to the Chinese company XueMei Education.

The Suffield board member, Lillian Chen, who runs the company with her husband, also resigned last month.

XueMei, which is headquartered in Shanghai and claims to have an office in Newton, promised "high net worth" Chinese families that it could "ensure admission" to private American high schools in exchange for payment. Cahn headlined events for the company in China and met with its customers.

There is no public evidence of financial wrongdoing by Cahn, 56, and he has not been charged with any crime. The Globe cannot independently confirm the focus of the IRS investigation, and the IRS has not responded to requests for comment. Suffield has said the investigation concerns Cahn's personal finances, not the school's, and it has hired outside legal counsel to conduct an internal investigation.

In a statement Sunday, Cahn's attorney, Duncan Levin, said his client spent 34 years at Suffield Academy, including 22 as the head of school.

"He loves the Suffield community and is proud of what he, the faculty, and the staff have built together," Levin said. "As he steps down, he wants the school to be able to focus on its students. He fully supports Casey Bobo and has every confidence in Casey's leadership."

Cahn's resignation marks a stunning end to his tenure as Suffield's head of school, which was widely regarded as transformational for the

SUFFIELD, Page A7

Wu renews stalled street, bike projects

Advocates see progress but remain cautious after city planner died in crash

By Niki Griswold
GLOBE STAFF

The list of public works projects read like the campaign promises of a mayor who pledged to adapt the streets of Boston to get more people walking, biking, and taking public transit.

Protective posts have been reinstalled on bike lanes in downtown Boston; a large-scale overhaul of Blue Hill Avenue is charging forward; and plans are underway for new Bluebikes stations in Roslindale, West Roxbury, and Hyde Park. And just recently, Boston officials installed protected bike lanes and other safety changes on a block in Mission Hill where a city transportation planner was struck and killed while cycling in July.

In some ways, the recent street changes harken back to Mayor Michelle Wu's first mayoral race, when expanding bike and bus lanes was a key pillar of her pitch to voters. But these projects are coming in her second term, after a tumultuous period in which Wu put much of this work on hold as she faced intense backlash over some street changes and a reelection challenge.

That pause triggered an extended period of uncertainty, divided residents, and caused turmoil within her staff. But a tragic catalyst for the latest developments came more than three months ago, when the death of city bikeshare and streets planner Louisa Gag sparked a firestorm of grief, outrage, and demands that Wu take action to make the city's roads safer.

Now, Wu's response is taking shape.

For the moment, bike and transit advocates are watching with cautious optimism. After more than a year in which they say they received little to no communication from City Hall on streets proj-

STREETS, Page A7

After Flock, Quincy has a new vendor

Surveillance tech collects its own set of complaints

By Yogev Toby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Quincy residents rallied for months against the city's use of surveillance cameras that read license plates, joining a national push to hit the brakes on the technology from Flock Safety. Finally, in late October, the City Council heard their cries and passed a resolution, 8 to 1, to cut ties with the company.

But just four days later, on Oct. 23, longtime Mayor Thomas Koch announced the city would hire a different vendor, again with no public input or competitive bid process.

"This is a strong good-faith effort to strike a balance between the investigative value of this technology and the legitimate concerns raised by our residents and across the nation," Koch wrote in his announcement.

The new vendor, OdinEye, promises some features to address residents' gripes, such as end-to-end encryption and keeping license plate data out of the hands of unauthorized individuals (something Boston struggled with). It also imposes

QUINCY, Page A6

Blink, you'll mist it

Monday: Some showers.
High 55-60. Low 42-47.
Tuesday: Partly sunny.
High 54-59. Low 44-49.
Sunrise: 6:27 Sunset: 4:28
Obituaries, **B7**
Comics and Weather, **D5-6**

VOL. 310, NO. 132
*
Suggested retail price
$4.00

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Boston Archbishop Richard Henning and Massachusetts bishops criticized Governor Maura Healey over her emergency implementation of an abortion law. **B1.**

The Bruins struck early in their 4-1 win over the Panthers, bringing their winning streak to four straight games Sunday. **C1.**

The Lenox Hotel in Boston shut down its overnight stays over the weekend for a full renovation that will cost about $100,000 per room. **D1.**

President Trump said he thinks his administration was too aggressive on deportations in his first major interview since the midterm elections. **A2.**

Nvidia is investigating its chief executive after he acknowledged an affair with a business executive alleged to be a Chinese spy. **A4.**

Some local businesses are getting a taste of stardom after being featured on Netflix's "Love Is Blind," where the cups are gold and new relationships are tested. **D1.**



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

PACKERS TORCH PATRIOTS

The New England Patriots had one of their worst performances of the season on Sunday in Foxborough, never looking competitive in a blowout 45-27 loss to the Green Bay Packers. Isaiah McDuffie sacked Drake Maye during the first quarter. **C1.**